

Teotihuacán

An ancient metropolis of vast proportions that thrived for centuries and wielded immense power

The magnificent Mesoamerican city of Teotihuacán in central Mexico was built between the 1st and 7th centuries CE. At its peak, in around 600 CE, it supported a population of more than 150,000 and had tremendous economic, cultural, and religious importance in the region.

City of the gods

Little is known about the language and identity of Teotihuacán's founders. The Nahuatl-speaking Aztecs discovered the ruins of the city centuries after its decline and, believing that only gods could have created its colossal pyramids, named it Teotihuacán, or "city of the gods." Built as a model of the Mesoamerican cosmos, almost everything in it had ritual or religious significance.

The city's ceremonial center includes three vast monuments: the pyramids of the Sun and the Moon and the Temple of Quetzalcóatl, the mythical plumed serpent. Of these, the largest is the Pyramid of the Sun, the third largest pyramid in the world. Teotihuacán's architectural splendor is matched by its artistic wealth: breathtaking stone sculptures and reliefs, as well as vivid murals, are found all over the city. The Teotihuacáanos also produced textiles, pottery, and other artifacts, including striking masks.

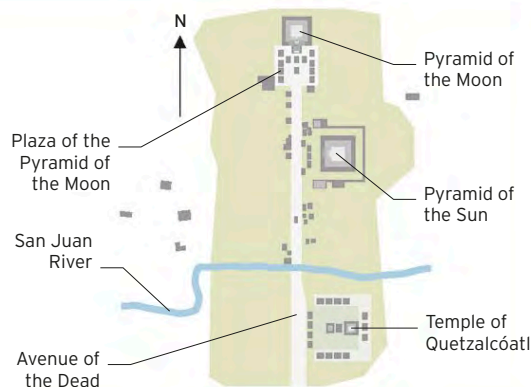
The civilization fell suddenly and mysteriously sometime after 550 CE—the exact cause of its collapse continues to elude scholars. Teotihuacán was designated a World Heritage Site in 1987.

The city's **wealth** was derived from a rare **obsidian**, a volcanic glass mined in the region



URBAN PLANNING

Built on a grid plan, Teotihuacán is considered one of the world's most impressive examples of urban planning. The principal street, the Avenue of the Dead, is more than 2 miles (3 km) long and includes the three major monuments: the Pyramid of the Sun, the Pyramid of the Moon, and the Temple of Quetzalcóatl.



◀ TEOTIHUACÁN MASK

A spectacular and emblematic piece of Teotihuacán art, this stone funerary mask was created c.200–550 CE, with further decoration added several centuries later. It is inlaid with turquoise, amazonite, coral, obsidian, and shell.